Migration Now Dossier

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The Courtauld

Critical Debates: *Migrations* - Portfolio

Migration Now Dossier

Concentration: MA History of Art: *Culture Wars: Art and Socialism Since 1917*

Professor(s): Group B: Chadwick / Mileeva

Word Count: 2,100

Unbalanced Frames: How Images of Displacement Are Seen, Hidden, and Perceived, in the Israel–Palestine Conflict

*(**Content Warning:** The following material contains sensitive subject matter, including a discussion of severe loss and trauma, that some readers may find upsetting. Reader discretion is advised.)*

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Our framework of visual culture has crafted a complex narrative surrounding the lives of both Israelis and Palestinians, who have endured displacement and loss. Global media and artistic representations of their suffering have revealed a striking imbalance. This dossier explores critical inquiries into how visual representations of violence and migration from Israel and Palestine create divergent frameworks of empathy and public awareness, as well as the ethical and political dilemmas that arise from this disparity. Drawing on the works of prominent scholars such as W.J.T. Mitchell, Judith Butler, and Ariella Azoulay, this analysis will focus on photographs, artistic creations, and digital media related to the Gaza-Israel conflict, with particular emphasis on the ethical quandaries surrounding themes of migration.

Historically, the intertwined narratives of the Israeli and Palestinian people revolved around migration. The twentieth century witnessed a dramatic scale of forced migration in the Middle East. Jewish families were forced to flee from the horrors of antisemitic persecution across Asia and Europe. This exodus, fueled by the Holocaust, led to the establishment of the State of Israel in 1948.[1] Concurrently, approximately 700,000 Palestinians endured forced displacement during the Nakba, or "catastrophe," a term encapsulating the profound loss of their villages and the upheaval resulting from the Arab-Israeli conflict.[2] The narratives of return and loss that emerged from these two critical events continue to shape the visual and political discourse surrounding the region. Both communities have nurtured a diasporic memory rooted in their experiences of exile, often harnessed within global narratives that exhibit a bias in their portrayal of suffering.

[1] Office of the Historian, U.S. Department of State, "Creation of Israel, 1948," *Milestones: 1945–1952* (accessed December 2025), https://history.state.gov/milestones/1945-1952/creation-israel.
[2] United Nations, "About the Nakba," UNISPAL (accessed December 2025), https://www.un.org/unispal/about-the-nakba/.

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On October 7, 2023, a violent assault by Hamas, a Palestinian military group and the governing body of the Palestinian people, resulted in the massacre and rape of Israeli civilians, including children.[3] The motivations behind such acts, whether for public spectacle, ideological purposes, or religious justification, merit rigorous condemnation and analysis. This event reignited global scrutiny surrounding the continuous loss of life on both sides of the conflict. In its wake, Israeli airstrikes targeted Gaza, leading to significant death, destruction, and the displacement of countless civilians. The ensuing wave of casualties starkly highlighted the imbalance in media coverage. Western news outlets and social media platforms primarily framed the grievances of Palestinians within a humanitarian context. At the same time, the narratives surrounding Jewish victims were often scrutinized, positioning them as merely collateral in a broader counterterrorism narrative.

Contemporary coverage of the Israel-Palestine conflict demonstrates that the battle for public perception is waged through visual culture. Images are not simply circulated or suppressed; they are meticulously curated to shape collective empathy and reinforce prevailing narratives. W.J.T. Mitchell's insight that images possess political "desire" and agency is particularly relevant here: images "demand" to be seen and interpreted, yet institutional gatekeepers carefully regulate their visibility.[4] This dynamic is acutely apparent in the Gaza War (2023/24), where the distribution of visual evidence reveals deep asymmetries in how suffering is presented.[5] The visual image of the Israeli victim, Shani Louk, [6] a 22-year-old woman who

[3] French Ministry for Europe and Foreign Affairs, "Israel — Commemoration of the October 7 Terrorist Attacks: 07-10-25," (accessed 2025), https://www.diplomatie.gouv.fr/en/country-files/israel-palestine/news/2025/article/israel-commemoration-of-the-october-7-terrorist-attacks-07-10-25.

[4] W.J.T. Mitchell, *What Do Pictures Want? The Lives and Loves of Images* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2005), 33.

[5] United Nations Digital Library, "Record: 4051246," (accessed 2025), https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/4051246?ln=en&v=pdf.

[6] Figure 1: Portrait of Shani Louk (pre-October 7, widely circulated by family). Figure 1 is a photograph of Shani Louk, a 22-year-old Israeli–German woman whose image circulated globally and became central to

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was brutally murdered and violated by Hamas. Her lifeless, mangled body, piled in a truck surrounded by jubilant Palestinian assailants, sends a mixed viewpoint, both evoking suffering yet showing a celebration. Whereas the imagery presented by the media of the ill Palestinian boy being held by his mother evoked a singular sympathy for the Palestinian suffering, even though the image was later proven to be a deceptive image.[7] This discrepancy is not coincidental; Roland Barthes identifies it as the construction of "myth," a process by which selective imagery legitimizes dominant perspectives and effaces alternative experiences.[8] Judith Butler's theory of "grievability" further illuminates the stakes: media decisions about which lives are mourned and which are rendered invisible perpetuate a hierarchy of suffering that urgently demands ethical attention.[9] By foregrounding these mechanisms, we see that the politics of image-making is inseparable from the politics of conflict itself.

Ariella Azoulay's theory of the "civil contract of photography" underscores that images of violence are active appeals for recognition, never mere documentation, but dynamic interventions in public discourse.[10] Yet, these appeals are often stifled or manipulated by those with the power to control visual narratives. By analyzing a range of visual artifacts, portraits, infographics, and activist posters, this essay demonstrates how selective image reproduction not only shapes perception but also actively defines the ethical and political boundaries of the conflict. A comparative visual approach reveals that images are not passive reflections of

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debates on media visibility and selective reporting during the 2023–24 Israel-Hamas war. The widespread dispersal of Louk's smiling pre-event photograph contrasts sharply with the limited mainstream visibility of later images, illustrating how news outlets curate a victim's identity to control public emotional response.

[7] Figure 2. Hidayat Al-Motawaq holds her 18-month-old son, Mohammad Al-Motawaq, in their tent in the Gaza Strip on Aug. 3."Photos of a starving baby in Gaza shocked the world. Here's how he's doing now." False narrative of a sick child being held by his mother. Article written by Anas Baba and Emily Feng. Source: NPR, Updated August 7, 20251:28 PM ET, Heard on *All Things Considered.* https://www.npr.org/2025/08/05/nx-s1-5488798/gaza-baby-starvation-update

[8] Roland Barthes. *Camera Lucida: Reflections on Photography.* Translated by Richard Howard. New York: Hill and Wang, 1981. 27.

[9] Judith Butler, *Frames of War: When Is Life Grievable?* (London: Verso, 2009), 22.

[10] Ariella Azoulay, *The Civil Contract of Photography* (New York: Zone Books, 2008), 14.

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geopolitical realities; rather, they construct and even transform them. Acknowledging this transformative power is essential if we are to address the systemic injustices perpetuated through visual culture.

The protracted history of tension between these regions is deeply rooted. Following the Holocaust, the displacement of Jewish populations led to their return to ancestral lands, an event met with opposition from Arab communities, ultimately resulting in reciprocal military control and conflict. The migration of Israeli citizens has never ended. Today, there is still internal displacement as Hezbollah, the terrorist organization near the Lebanese border have caused many Israelis' further displacement. While blame has been placed on Israel, it has been the terrorist organization, Hamas, that has taken over the Gaza region, and their lack of humanitarian empathy that has fostered further migration of the Palestinian people. Collectively, all of these terrorist organizations, such as Hamas and Hezbollah, have been the recent variable of internal migration for the Israelis and forced displacement for the Palestinians.

Drawing on the theoretical contributions of Barthes, Mitchell, and Azoulay, it becomes evident that the media's treatment of Shani Louk's death transformed it into an ideological image, one that mobilizes only selective sympathy and reinforces extant political narratives. These dynamics are articulated in the scholarship of these theorists, who argue that the media's minimization and partial suppression of imagery signal a deliberate, politically motivated narrative construction. Rather than allowing images to freely circulate and influence perception, media organizations actively restricted their visibility in favor of alternative narratives, exemplifying how image management and selective reproduction serve as mechanisms of ideological control. Media coverage of the Israeli-Gaza conflict case illustrates institutional regulation of visibility, shaping public comprehension of violence through curated dissemination

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of images. Roland Barthes, in *Mythologies*, posits that media bias functions not only through what is made visible but also through strategic omission; the marginalization of Louk's photograph operates as an "empty signifier," an absence that circumscribes meaning by forestalling her suffering from attaining symbolic centrality.[11] W.J.T. Mitchell contends that images possess political agency, which elucidates why the photograph of Louk's body, capable of eliciting potent emotional and ideological responses, may have been suppressed or neglected.[12] The image itself "demanded" a reaction that challenged prevailing media framings, motivating institutions to exert control over its circulation. Walter Benjamin's analysis of technological reproducibility provides further insight, suggesting that even in an era of digital proliferation, traditional media retain considerable authority in determining which acts of violence achieve widespread recognition and which are marginalized.[13] Collectively, these theoretical frameworks underscore that images like that of Shani Louk and the image of the sick Palestinian child are emblematic of a broader regime of narrative management, wherein the politics of visibility and invisibility fundamentally reconfigure collective perceptions of conflict and victimhood.

Susan Sontag, in her thought-provoking work *Regarding the Pain of Others*, articulated that photographs depicting violence are never neutral; they inherently "frame" suffering, provoking varying responses of sympathy or desensitization.[14] This phenomenon has been intensified in the digital age, where social media amplifies emotional reactions through sensationalized content, leading viewers to engage with these distressing images in a detached,

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[11] Roland Barthes, *Camera Lucida: Reflections on Photography*, trans. Richard Howard (New York: Hill and Wang, 1981), 27.
[12] Mitchell, *What Do Pictures Want?*, 33.
[13] Walter Benjamin, "The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technological Reproducibility," in *The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technological Reproducibility, and Other Writings on Media*, ed. Michael W. Jennings, Brigid Doherty, and Thomas Y. Levin, trans. Edmund Jephcott (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2008), 19–55.
[14] Susan Sontag, *Regarding the Pain of Others* (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2003), 71-85.

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faceless manner. Consequently, the "visual fatigue" resulting from repeated portrayals of victimization fosters a rhetorical defense.

A discernible pattern emerges across visual artifacts, where media institutions selectively determine which images gain prominence and which remain marginal. While digital platforms have expanded opportunities for circulation, editorial choices continue to shape which representations hold authority. For example, the many images seen of a bombed and decimated Gaza.[15] Competing activist visual cultures reveal that although many photos are produced, only some are widely amplified. Thus, visibility becomes a contested arena, personal versus collective, symbolic versus statistical, national grief versus global solidarity. These hierarchies do not simply mirror the conflict; they actively shape its perception.

Across the corpus of visual artifacts examined (Figures 1–4), the politics of visibility emerges as a critical determinant in shaping public understanding. Although digital platforms ostensibly democratize image circulation, editorial interventions remain decisive in governing which representations attain prominence. Walter Benjamin articulates that the reproducibility of images does not dissolve the ideological frameworks that confer meaning upon them.[16] This dynamic is emblematic of Roland Barthes's theory of *myth*, wherein the absence of specific images, what remains unseen, serves ideological functions as potently as what is rendered visible.[17] Ariella Azoulay's concept of the "civil contract of photography" further elucidates the

[15] Figure 4. Israel hits Gaza Strip with the equivalent of two nuclear bombs. Image of the destroyed Gaza Strip after an Israeli military strike. Israel using approximately 25,000 tons of explosives on the Gaza Strip since October 7, the beginning of the conflict. Source: Euro-Med Human Rights Monitor, 2023. URL:https://euromedmonitor.org/en/article/5908/Israel-hits-Gaza-Strip-with-the-equivalent-of-two-nuclear-bombs.
[16] Benjamin, "The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technological Reproducibility," in *The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technological Reproducibility, and Other Writings on Media*, 19–55.
[17] Roland Barthes, *Camera Lucida: Reflections on Photography*, trans. Richard Howard (New York: Hill and Wang, 1981), 27.

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participatory role of audiences, who negotiate these visual regimes by either acquiescing to or contesting the frames imposed upon them.[18]

This imbalance is reiterated through the comparison of the Israeli "Bring Them Home"[19] hostage campaign and the Palestinian "Ceasefire Now" protest poster.[20] The Israeli campaign employs clean portraiture, vibrant color palettes, and emotionally direct messaging, visual strategies optimized for viral dissemination and rapid audience recognition.[21] Following W.J.T. Mitchell's insight, such images "demand" attention by foregrounding identifiable faces, inviting viewers to contemplate the specificity of each individual life.[22] In contrast, Palestinian protest graphics utilize symbolic motifs, such as olive branches, keffiyeh patterns, and declarative text to situate the conflict within a broader narrative of collective struggle and liberation. These design choices privilege political structure over personal narrative. This differential amplification illustrates how visual strategies, in concert with institutional gatekeeping, generate uneven narrative potency across communities. Ultimately, these enhanced visual narratives reveal bias in the mediation of suffering, which perpetuates hierarchies of empathy and grievability. These visual narratives reinforced the broader ideological frameworks within which audiences are compelled to interpret the Israel-Palestine conflict.

Within the realm of contemporary art, figures such as Banksy, a globally acclaimed and provocative street artist, utilize creative expression as a powerful tool for sociopolitical

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[18] Ariella Azoulay, *The Civil Contract of Photography* (New York: Zone Books, 2008), 14.
[19] Figure 5. Israeli Government Instagram Post (Non-Graphic), "Bring Them Home" Hostage Campaign. Social media campaign graphic featuring portraits of Israeli hostages, highlighting how grassroots digital activism leverages simple, repeatable imagery to increase visibility. This contrasts with the relative absence of similar Palestinian personal portrait campaigns in mainstream Western feeds.
[20] Figure 6: Palestinian Protest Poster , "Ceasefire Now" (Non-Graphic). Common protest poster used across global pro-Palestine marches in 2023–24. This poster features bold typography and symbolic imagery. Such as olive branches and keffiyeh patterns. As an activist visual artifact, it reflects the global framing of Palestinians as structurally oppressed and appeals to solidarity movements.
[21] Allan Sekula, "The Body and the Archive," *October* 39 (1986): 3–64.
[22] Mitchell, *What Do Pictures Want?*, 33.

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commentary. The mural "Girl Frisking Soldier"[23] offers a poignant critique of authority and occupation, igniting rigorous discourse on power dynamics and the ethics of control. Through such evocative imagery, artistic interventions transcend conventional news narratives, fostering critical engagement and catalyzing transformative dialogue within the political landscape.

Photographs and other visual materials demonstrate that migration, as experienced in Gaza and Israel, is not merely a matter of territorial dislocation or political unrest, but is fundamentally shaped by visual storytelling. The interplay of images, posters, and artworks creates a space for recognition, inviting viewers to confront the complexity of human experience, sometimes illuminated or obscured, to serve competing interests.

As the intertwined histories of the Jewish and Palestinian people are marked by displacement and collective trauma, the visual representations analyzed here lay bare the fractures in prevailing regimes of empathy and moral obligation. This resonates on a global scale, as audiences are increasingly called upon to witness vulnerability and suffering in distant contexts.

Theorists such as Judith Butler, Susan Sontag, and Ariella Azoulay have persuasively argued that photographs are not passive records of events but transformative agents that shape moral consciousness. Engaging with these images allows us to discern which experiences become emblematic of suffering and which are relegated to the margins of public awareness. This engagement exposes the vulnerabilities and asymmetries embedded in the visual mediation of migration.

[23] Figure 7: Banksy Artwork, "Girl Frisking Soldier" (West Bank, 2007). Banksy's mural depicts a young girl frisking an Israeli soldier in reverse power dynamics. This artwork is oftenly reused in discussions of the conflict, becoming a widely spread visual account for critiques of occupation. Illustrating how artistic imagery transforms political interpretation that goes past immediate news events.

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Collectively, the visual comparisons presented in this essay expose a media ecology in which representational asymmetry distinctly configures public perceptions of Israeli and Palestinian suffering. The rendering of Israeli victims and the Palestinian casualties perpetuates what Butler has termed differential "frames of war," privileging some lives as immediately grievable while consigning others to abstraction.[24] Mitchell's analysis of the political life of images underscores the non-neutrality of these patterns, which are sustained by institutional interests.[25] Barthes's notion of myth elucidates the naturalization of these selective visibilities, making inequalities of empathy appear given rather than constructed.[26] Azoulay's civil contract of photography reminds us that every image issues an ethical summons, one that is frequently mediated, muted, or redirected by editorial discretion.[27] The Israel–Palestine conflict thus reveals that media bias is as much visual as it is textual. Through their control over which images are seen, how they are contextualized, and the channels through which they circulate, media institutions exercise power over the political imagination itself. Ultimately, the contestation over images is inseparable from struggles over territory, rights, memory, and justice, a testament to the enduring significance of what remains unseen as well as what is brought to light.

[24] Butler, *Frames of War: When Is Life Grievable?*, 1-32.
[25] Mitchell, *What Do Pictures Want?*, 33.
[26] Barthes, *Camera Lucida: Reflections on Photography*, trans. Richard Howard, 27.
[27] Azoulay, *The Civil Contract of Photography* (New York: Zone Books, 2008), 14.

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Portrait of Shani Louk. Widely circulated by the family before October 7, 2023.

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A photograph that circulated on social media displaying Shani Louk, a German-Israeli civilian, on a Hamas pickup truck following the October 7 attack.

Source: The Jewish Chronicle. *Outrage as picture showing body of murdered hostage Shani Louk wins competition: The shocking photo was among a collection of Israel-Hamas war photos awarded Team Picture Story of the Year in the world's oldest photojournalism award.*

URL:https://www.thejc.com/news/world/outrage-as-photograph-showing-body-of-shani-louk-wins-competition-rd8tv6qq

Figure 2. Hidayat Al-Motawaq holds her 18-month-old son, Mohammad Al-Motawaq, in their tent in the Gaza Strip on Aug. 3.

"Photos of a starving baby in Gaza shocked the world. Here's how he's doing now." False narrative of a sick child being held by his mother. Article written by Anas Baba and Emily Feng.

Source: NPR, Updated August 7, 20251:28 PM ET, Heard on *All Things Considered.*

URL: https://www.npr.org/2025/08/05/nx-s1-5488798/gaza-baby-starvation-update

Figure 3. *Portrait of Shani Louk (Pre–October 7).*

A personal photograph shared by Louk's family. This photograph was also used in international reporting.

Source: BBC News coverage of October 7 hostages, 2023.

URL: https://www.bbc.com/news/world-middle-east-67240526

Figure 4. Israel hits the Gaza Strip with the equivalent of two nuclear bombs.

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Image of the destroyed Gaza Strip after an Israeli military strike. Israel using approximately 25,000 tons of explosives on the Gaza Strip since October 7, the beginning of the conflict.

Source: Euro-Med Human Rights Monitor, 2023.

URL:https://euromedmonitor.org/en/article/5908/Israel-hits-Gaza-Strip-with-the-equivalent-of-two-nuclear-bombs

Figure 5. *"Bring Them Home Now" Hostage Posters.*

Grassroots visual campaign by families of Israeli hostages, displayed globally.

Source: Hostages and Missing Families Forum, 2023.

URL: https://www.bringthemhomenow.net

Figure 6. *"Ceasefire Now" Protest Poster.*

Heavily circulated pro-Palestinian activist poster used in demonstrations worldwide.

Source: Example from *Creative Review. The design story of the Gaza ceasefire marches.*

URL: https://www.creativereview.co.uk/design-story-gaza-ceasefire-marches/

Figure 7. Banksy, *Girl Frisking Soldier*, 2007.

Stencil mural created on the West Bank barrier wall.

Source: Banksy Street Art Archive.

URL: https://www.banksy.co.uk/outdoor

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Ilustrations

Figure 1.



Figure 1. *Shani Louk in the Truck,* October 7, 2023. Photograph. Source: The Jewish Chronicle.

Figure 2.



Figure 2. *Hidayat Al-Motawaq holds her 18-month-old son*, Mohammad Al-Motawaq, in their tent in the Gaza Strip on Aug. 3. Article & Podcast: “Photos of a starving baby in Gaza shocked the world. Here's how he's doing now.” False narrative of a sick child being held by his mother.

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Figure 3.



Figure 3. *Portrait of Shani Louk (Pre–October 7),* 2023, Photograph, Source: BBC News.

Figure 4.



Figure 4. Israel hits the Gaza Strip with the equivalent of two nuclear bombs, 2023, Photograph, Source: Euro-Med Human Rights Monitor.

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Figure 5.



Figure 5. *"Bring Them Home Now" Hostage Posters.* 2023. Source: Bring Them Home Now.

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Figure 6. *"Ceasefire Now" Protest Poster.* 2023. Source: The Creative Review.

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Figure 7.



Figure 7. *Girl Frisking Soldier*, 2007. Mural created by Banksy, Source: Banksy.co

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